THE SHE LIST

THE ACE FACTOR

Alia Bhatt, *30*
Actress

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Won National Award for *Gangubai Kathiawadi*; made her Hollywood debut with *Heart of Stone* and had a Rs 100 crore–plus hit in *Rocky aur Rani...*

THERE ARE SEVERAL REASONS why many regard Alia Bhatt as a once-in-a-generation kind of actress, whose ability to draw audiences to the theatres is not courtesy her striking appearance, her social media avatar or the director or actor she is working with. You see an Alia Bhatt film because you believe that, give her material to bite into, and she will devour it and turn it into a memorable thing.

↘ BACK-UP PLAN If she didn't bag *Student of the Year*, Alia was determined to go off to London to study theatre

↘ ON HER WISHLIST A comedy. "I'd really like to work with Rohit Shetty who commands that space and has done so successfully"

It's impressive because there's no elaborate method to it. "I get bored of the character if I start working on it months in advance," she told INDIA TODAY after the success of *Gangubai Kathiawadi*. "I like to just live it in front of the camera. It is the catalyst that gets the performance out." Not for her the tedium of copious note-taking. "Even when I saw *Mandi*, what I took from observation was way more special than if I had taken from what went behind it," says Alia. That's not to say there's no hard work to her process. Natural talent, she's aware, can only take you so far. For *Raazi*, she learned the Morse code, how to drive a tempo and brushed up her Hindi "so it didn't sound Juhu-ish"; for *Udta Punjab*, she turned social media recluse so that she could play a young migrant battling drug addiction and trauma.

After nearly a decade in acting, Alia, like many others, wants to take more ownership of her art and be involved in its making. Hence Eternal Sunshine, her production company with which she hopes to give new writers and directors fresh opportunity. That earnest effort led to *Darlings* (Netflix).

Alia knows something her contemporaries perhaps do not. That there will be projects that will be bigger than her (*RRR, Brahmastra*) and those where she will be able to flex her thespian muscle (*Highway, Udta Punjab, Raazi*). There's also the desire to delve into parts that lie outside her comfort zone. That's why she identified so much with Veera, her character in *Highway*, a role she did at a young 21. "She has everything, yet there is something missing," says Alia. "She needs something more, but doesn't know what. That's what I connected to. I knew I needed something more." It's a self-awareness that tells you Alia will go a long way. ■

–Suhani Singh

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